Kaluchak massacre in May 2002. Although cross-LoC infiltration soon resumed, violence measured in terms of fatalities and the number of violent incidents began declining after 2002.[82] There were several reasons for this. A key driver was Pakistan's efforts to calibrate the tempo of operations in response to pressure from New Delhi and Washington. In addition, the Deobandi groups were also no longer as robust and many of their militants were no longer as focused on the Kashmir jihad. JeM had been the second most active Pakistani group after Lashkar at the turn of the century, but it was pulled in different directions after 9/11 and its footprint in Indian-administered Kashmir shrank significantly over the years. The 2002 elections in Indian-administered Kashmir were also seen to be mostly free and fair. This contributed to the normalizing of politics within the region, though it must be said that the expected improvements in governance did not materialize. Finally, the introduction of fencing along the LoC in 2003 made infiltration more difficult, while India's counter-insurgency capabilities also continued to improve.

Lashkar was already the most powerful Pakistani militant outfit in Indian-administered Kashmir by 2001 and remained focused on that front thereafter, in contradistinction to the Deobandi groups. It was also more amenable to state control and thus more willing to abide by directives to increase or decrease the tempo of operations. Thus it became the primary, though not the only, vehicle for waging a 'controlled jihad.' The ISI began sending smaller groups of fighters across the LoC and became more selective about the militants with whom it worked.[83] This favored Lashkar, which was the state's most reliable proxy, and its militants are reported to have begun operating in smaller groups as befit a more calibrated jihad.[84] The group also relied on cadres already in Indian-administered Kashmir, where by one estimate it had approximately 1,500 militants by 2002. This amounted to roughly half of the total number of militants from Pakistani jihadi groups in the Kashmir theater at the time.[85] This meant it could maintain a level of militant activity inside Indian-administered Kashmir even during those periods when the ISI was directing it to reduce infiltrations across the LoC.

Lashkar also increased its focus on indigenous recruitment in Indian-administered Kashmir. Enhancing its local network enabled Lashkar to reduce its practice of contracting out logistics. Most non-Kashmiri groups